For Delhi and Beijing, the immediate post–Cold War era was reminiscent of the 1950s. India and China soon found themselves ranged against the US and were joined by Russia. All three powers cooperated with the US, which dominated world politics, but for the first time since the mid-1950s, they also found themselves in a loose entente against America.

Tiananmen Square and China–US tensions

As the Cold War ended, a new era began, with a Chinese thunderclap. With a decade of transformative economic growth and social change in China, pressures for a political opening had built up. The Soviet reforms under Gorbachev and the collapse of communism in Eastern Europe undoubtedly also had an effect on a generation of young Chinese who wanted a loosening of government control over their lives. The pro-democracy movement was at its strongest in Beijing. Beginning in April 1989, a wave of protests washed over the capital city and spread to scores of other parts of the mainland. The movement peaked in the June Fourth Incident in Beijing's iconic Tiananmen Square when the CPC leadership sent the military armed with tanks into the square to clear the protests. Estimates vary on the numbers killed and injured, but the heavy hand of repression led to international criticism including in the US, China's erstwhile ally.

While Washington condemned Beijing's actions, it continued to do business with China. Ordinary Americans and the human rights community in the US were shocked, but President George Bush 'took a conciliatory approach . . . he deplored the loss of life, but he did not criticize individual party leaders' in order to stay engaged. US arms sales to China were suspended, but the president sent his NSA and deputy secretary of state to meet Deng Xiaoping. He wrote Deng three letters. In one extraordinary passage, he wrote almost like a supplicant: 'Please do not be angry with me if I have crossed the invisible threshold lying between constructive suggestion and "internal interference"'. A few months later, his NSA would shake Deng's hand and gush, 'My president wants you to know he is your